



Think PC

The PC—as in “personal computer”—is what technology is first associated with. The ‘80s was when “PC” began to mean “IBM PC”

There’s a pattern to the development of technology: in the early days are written all the seminal papers, and are made all the breakthrough inventions and innovations; later on come things that build upon these old foundations. Compared to decades such as the ‘40s, when the transistor was invented, little was actually *invented* in the ‘80s. But a lot was built upon, and computing reached critical mass—it was no longer something for the geeks.

The ‘80s were the decade of personal computing more than anything else—not just in terms of technology, but in *general* terms. This is reflected in Time Magazine’s choosing of the PC as the “Man” of the Year in 1982. We wish we had a copy. (We’re sure there’s one for sale on eBay.)

1984 may have been when the Mac came out, but August 1981 saw the launch of the IBM PC. And that’s the date the non-Macaholics amongst us celebrate: the dark ages of computing were over. We’d reached what has merely evolved and tided us through thus far.

Apple innovated and Microsoft followed, but IBM chose DOS for its PCs. That’s what’s important to folks like us who write stuff like this on a Wintel. The original arrangement, in 1981, between IBM and Microsoft as regards the machine and the OS, stated that MS would provide the base OS, and that both IBM and Microsoft would

then work on developing different parts of it in order to build a more powerful system. The companies were to then share the code they had arrived at.

Just to be accurate, PC-DOS was what was chosen as the IBM OS; it wasn’t very different from MS-DOS, which was reserved by Microsoft for non-IBM PCs. We should mention here that MS-DOS was reverse-engineered from the CP/M-86 OS, which was written by Digital Research!

Why DOS? There are rumours and theories aplenty, but here’s what we found as plausible explanations on reference.com:

“CP/M was by far the most popular OS in use at the time... there are at least two rumours about why IBM ended up licensing QDOS instead... One story is that Gary Kildall, creator of CP/M, simply refused to answer the door when representatives from IBM rang his doorbell. However, the most prevalent story... is that when IBM approached Kildall for a license, Kildall kept the IBM executives waiting for hours while he went flying in his airplane... IBM then turned to Microsoft to provide an operating system.”

The article, unfortunately, goes on to state—you guessed it—that neither story is “generally accepted” as true. We figure, therefore, that the story is much longer—do write in if you know!

(To clear the confusion between

QDOS and PC-DOS, MS licensed QDOS to IBM, which became PC-DOS 1.0 on the PC.)

Too much happened in the first half of the decade, really. The PC, the Mac, the Osborne 1, and the Walkman. “The Osborne 1” probably didn’t ring a bell there: it was the first laptop. Actually, it wasn’t a laptop: it was about the size of a briefcase. But it was portable. So well, the Osborne 1 by Adam Osborne weighed about 11 kg, shipped with a lot of software, and cost \$1,795 (which means several lakhs in today’s terms). But then there was the software, and some of the specs were attractive: 64 KB RAM, two floppy drives (5 ¼ inch) and also a modem. It, however, had only a 5-inch display. Mind you, it didn’t start off the portable computing revolution—Compaq and others came out with more workable models.

Going a level above “personal computing,” think of “personal technology”: it was *that* that the Walkman brought to the streets—literally. It was (obviously) still considered funny if you walked down a street with wires dangling from your ears: the Walkman overcame that little hurdle to popularity, and went on to become probably the most-celebrated single *gadget* of all time, in the strictest sense of the word.

The Apple Macintosh in 1984 was, formally, the first commercially-successful GUI-and-mouse

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